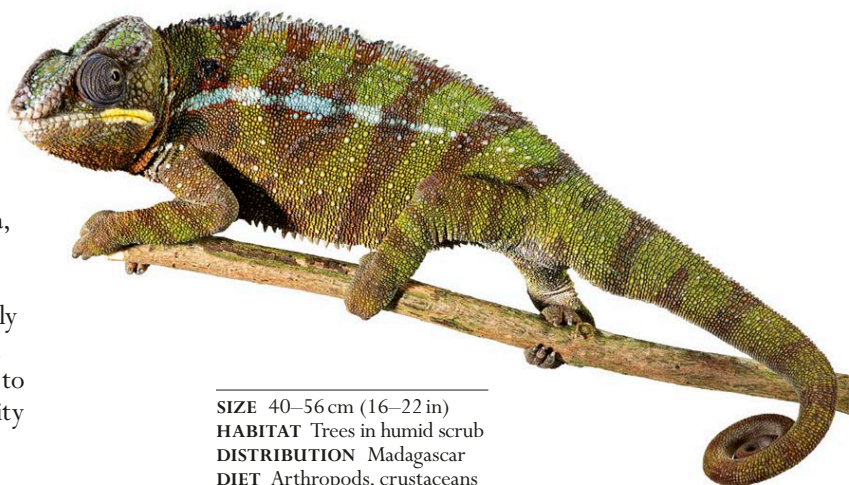


PANTHER CHAMELEON

Furcifer pardalis

This large chameleon is endemic to Madagascar off the east coast of southern Africa, and has also been introduced to Mauritius and Réunion. This species lives in trees in humid scrubland, and its feet are so well adapted for grasping branches that it is difficult for the lizard to walk across a flat surface. Active during the day, it moves slowly through the branches to hunt its insect food by stealth. When it spots its next meal, the chameleon focuses on its victim with both eyes, then shoots out its long tongue to grasp the insect and pull it back into its large mouth. The chameleon's uncanny ability to change colour is an indicator of mood and social status only, and is not used for camouflage. When faced with a rival, it rapidly inflates its body and changes colour, putting on a display of dominance that is usually enough to decide a dispute.



SIZE 40–56 cm (16–22 in)
HABITAT Trees in humid scrub
DISTRIBUTION Madagascar
DIET Arthropods, crustaceans

a ridge of protective
spines runs along the
midline of the back

casque, or bony shield,
at the back of the head

